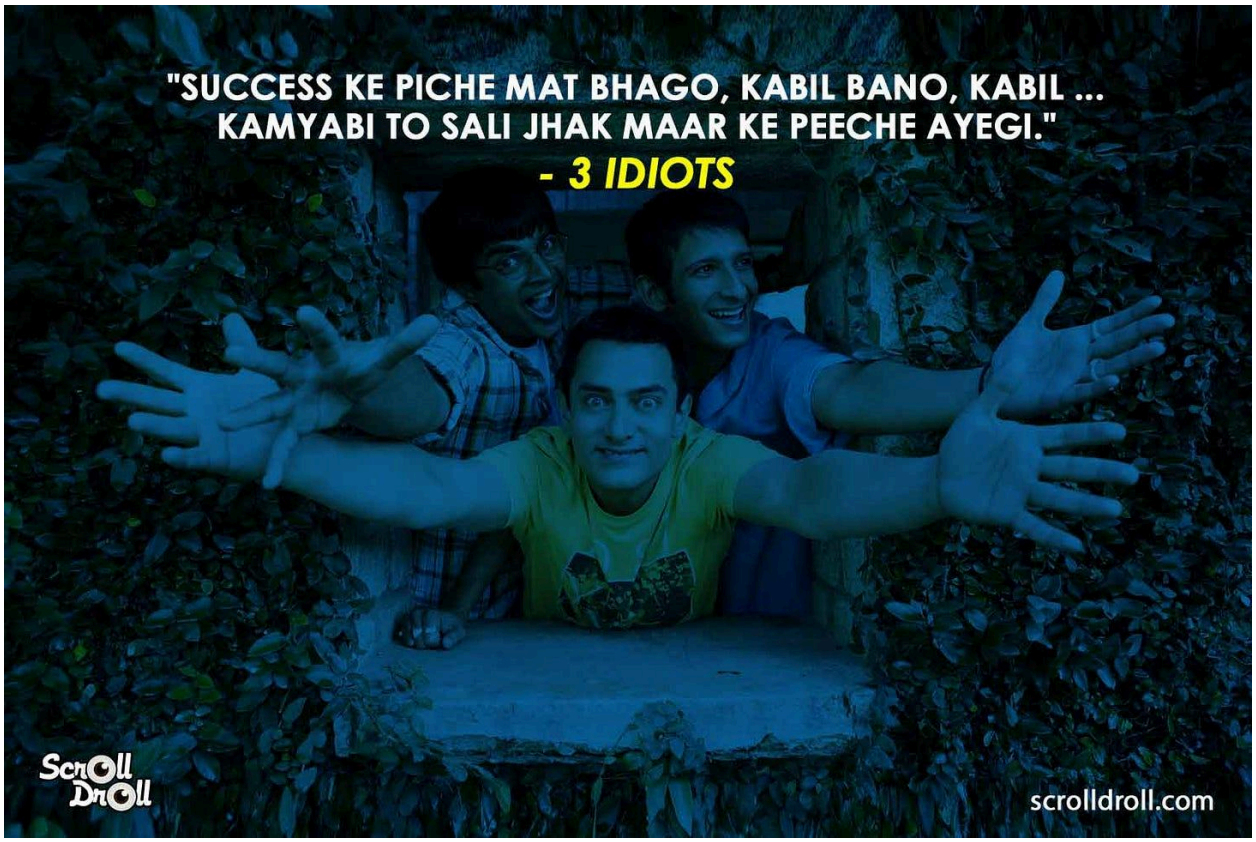
The Struggle of Bollywood Movies

"The box office is a ruthless judge. It doesn't care about star power or big budgets. It only cares about the audience's verdict."

The Bollywood industry has faced challenges since the lockdown, particularly regarding the performance of movies at the box office. Films like Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2, KGF 2, RRR, Gangubai Kathiawadi, Sooryavanshi, and Kashmir Files, which used to collect around 200 to 300 crores before the lockdown, have struggled to reach even 30 crores post-lockdown. This decline in box office earnings can be attributed to a lack of audience interest in mediocre movies. Moviegoers now prefer to watch blockbusters rather than average films. This shift in audience preference has led to the rise of OTT platforms in India, such as Hotstar, Sony Liv, and Jio. These platforms gained more viewership by streaming events like IPL for free, which introduced audiences to the world of streaming. Jio Cinema, for instance, acquired the rights for HBO Max and Warner Bros., bringing popular international content to Indian viewers.



One of the main issues in Bollywood is the repetitive screenplay and stories in movies. There seems to be a lack of originality and diversity in storytelling. Many movies follow a predictable pattern, with a hero who defeats all the villains, leaving little room for surprises or innovative narratives. To cater to the evolving tastes of the audience, Bollywood needs to explore new and exciting storylines that can engage and captivate viewers. The audience has expanded their viewing options to include international shows and web series, which often offer better storytelling. Consequently, the audience now seeks unique and engaging movies, such as RRR and Pushpa, which provide different experiences compared to typical action films.

Another concern in Bollywood is the abundance of remakes, particularly from South Indian films. Manish Shah popularised the dubbing of South Indian movies in Hindi, and now it seems that every other film is a remake of a South Indian or international film. The industry lacks originality, relying on existing successful formulas instead. Remaking movies is not a guaranteed path to success, as the film's box office performance ultimately depends on audience reception. Despite the occasional success of movies like Pathaan, several upcoming releases, including Selfiee, Shezada, and Tu Jhooti Main Makkar, have not fared well.

Post-COVID, the box office collections in Bollywood have suffered. According to Koimoi, 77% of Bollywood releases in a particular year were considered flops. Additionally, Hindi cinema's share of overall gross box office collections has decreased to just 34%, compared to the pre-pandemic levels. Regional language films have contributed significantly more to the box office revenues. In 2020, box office collections experienced an 81% decline compared to 2019. While there has been a slight recovery since then, the figures remain at only 34% of pre-pandemic levels. Hindi cinema's share of box office revenue has dropped to an all-time low of 10% in recent months, resulting in losses for theatre owners.

Nepotism is another contentious topic in Bollywood. It is prevalent in various industries, where individuals often provide opportunities for their family members. While it is natural for parents to support their children's aspirations, the debate arises when talented individuals without industry connections struggle to gain access to opportunities. The prevalence of nepotism in Bollywood has sparked debates about fairness and equal opportunities for aspiring actors. Adipurush continues to be the subject of dispute. Whether it be because of the offensive vocabulary, troubling moments, or incorrect character portrayals, people generally don't appear to be happy with the film's content. Although the writers have agreed to change the specific sentences that offended people's religious sensibilities, viewers do not believe this will accomplish their goal. The more important query in the midst of this uproar is how a film that ridicules Gods was approved by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) with no protests.

Overall, the Bollywood industry faces challenges in terms of box office performance, lack of originality in storytelling, and debates surrounding nepotism. However, with the industry's resilience, the anticipation of exciting new releases, and the rise of diverse content, there is hope for a revival in the future.